

THE LONG TREK Indian Army soldiers take part in Exercise Parvat Prahar in eastern Ladakh in September; below, PM Modi, President Xi at the SCO summit in Samarkand with other leaders

disputed Gogra Hot Springs area. It seems that though the Chinese were keen to set up a Modi-Xi meeting, possibly to demonstrate a state of normality in ties, New Delhi demurred, for it has been insisting on the pre-March 2020 status quo on the LAC, and felt that the optics emanating out of such a meeting would have been more advantageous to Beijing. Indeed, just a day after the disengagement process started, Chinese foreign ministry spokesperson Mao Ning, while calling it a "positive development", curtly added that Beijing will not accept "the status quo created by India's illegal crossing of the LAC". Insiders believe the breakthrough at PP15 was aimed at defusing any visible tension that might have existed between the leaders. For the photo op with other heads of state, Modi and Xi stood next to each other, but there were no smiles exchanged or hands shaken. The leaders would have another forum to warm up to each other, but what's worrying a section of army officers, defence experts and civilians more is the suspicion that the 'buffer zones' created at every point of disengagement at the LAC between the armies are on the Indian side of the de facto border, and thus by agreeing to abide by them, India risks losing control over some of its own territory.

A SENIOR ARMY OFFICER SAYS DE-ESCALATION IS NOT POSSIBLE SOON AS THE PLA HAS BUILT PERMANENT CAMPS, INFRASTRUCTURE ON THE LAC

Take the latest point of disengagement—PP15 in Gogra Hot Springs, also known as Jianan La. Its highest point, it is believed, allowed Indian patrols access to the entire Galwan Valley and the Depsang Bulge. The PLA is loath to let Indians near it, as they (the Chinese) have constructed a road from the bulge to Jianan La. This is why the Chinese took so long to agree to a troop pull-back. It also comes with a rider. Both armies have agreed on an over 3km-long 'buffer zone' or 'no patrolling area', meaning neither will venture into it till the matter is resolved.

The demilitarised areas were first created in the Galwan Valley (3km-wide) and Pangong Lake (10 km). Mutually agreed buffer zones also dot the area's major friction points, from Daulat Beg Oldie on the Chip Chap river to Raki Nala bottleneck, Galwan river (PP14), Kurang Nala (PP15), Gogra Post (PP17A), Pangong Tso North (Fingers 3-8), Pangong Tso South, the Kailash range on the Rezang La and the Depsang bulge (PP8). All these were areas accessible to Indian soldiers and treated as Indian territory till recently, when silent